



THE 13 KIBBE ARCHETYPES

An Introduction to the Kibbe Body Types



The Kibbe body types are an array of 13 style types based on physical characteristics (and personality essence).

The system was introduced by David Kibbe during the 1980s.

Unlike the traditional (fruit) body shape theory, which focuses on achieving balance and symmetry, Kibbe's archetypes are more in line with style essences theory.

aim at creating an
overall
harmonious style
image of a person
rather than
focusing on
styling individual
body parts.

I. Overview of the Kibbe Body Type System

In 1987, David Kibbe, an image professional based in New York City, published a book called ***Metamorphosis, A Personal Image And Style Book For Women***. In this book, Kibbe introduced a style type theory known today as the Kibbe archetype system.

If you want a copy of the book - which is out of print - you will need to dig deep into your pockets. Asking prices reach into the hundreds of dollars. You also have the option of being personally styled by David Kibbe in his NYC

The Kibbe Body Type System

The Kibbe body types are a total image system based largely on a person's balance of yin and yang (feminine and masculine energy). There are 13 different body types, each falling somewhere along two axes: yin/yang and contrast/blended.

Where on the spectrum a person lands depends on their physical characteristics (and personality essence) and will determine their Kibbe body type (or Kibbe image identity type). Each Kibbe body type comes with guidelines covering all elements of personal appearance, including clothing, hair and makeup. The aim is to achieve a complete, harmonious look.

Note: The Kibbe body types are not 'body types' per se. In Kibbe's book, the body types are referred to as archetypes or image identity types. These are comprehensive style guides based on a person's overall appearance and have very little to do with traditional body types (apple, pear etc). On the internet, Kibbe's archetype system has (incorrectly) become known as the Kibbe body type system, which is why I will use archetype and body type interchangeably in this article.

10 Other Body Type Theories

For David Kibbe, traditional style theories don't go far enough and are, in his view, extremely limiting. Their focus is on achieving balance and symmetry. Kibbe rejects these theories because he believes they lead to everyone looking the same. Instead, he encourages seeking true balance by embracing and emphasising one's natural appearance. Additionally, Kibbe suggests taking a holistic approach to appearance instead of following random fashion trends.

Rather than achieving symmetry, Kibbe's focus is on achieving harmony. By recreating your natural, unique Yin/Yang balance in your clothing, your clothes will look very natural on you. As opposed to trying to live up to a certain style type, Kibbe argues the need to follow your natural lines.

The main benefit that Kibbe's theory has over more traditional body type theories is that it is body-positive. It shows how drastically changing elements of your body (eg through plastic surgery) will not improve it but distort the native lines of your body.

Imagine a very lean, long body that has been significantly enhanced at the bust line. Or a very angular face on which the lips have been treated with filler to make them full and round. These

quite the opposite effect of what the procedures were supposed to achieve.

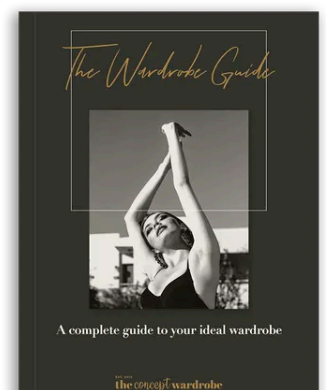
Kibbe's archetypes are very similar to another holistic style theory - style essences. Like the Kibbe body types, style essences are complete images and include recommendations on lines, silhouettes, fabrics, patterns and colours. Style essences were first introduced in the 1930s and 1940s by two professors of textile. Kibbe's archetype system is very similar to these style essences but differs in the number of essences.

For instance, style essence theory covers seven pure essences. Kibbe only uses five of those. Additionally, style essence theory allows for the mixing of all essences with each other. In Kibbe's theory, not all essences get combined to a unique archetype. Kibbe's body types are therefore more limited.

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Principles

Before we dive into the 13 body types, we need to understand their underlying principles. Without this understanding, there is a very high chance of getting your type wrong.

Yin & Yang

The principle of Yin and Yang is that **everything exists in inseparable and contradictory opposites**, for instance, female-male, dark-light, and old-young. Yin is considered feminine energy and yang is masculine energy.

However, this is not to be confused with femininity and masculinity per se. A strongly yang influenced body does not mean you look like a man. Understanding the terms themselves and how they apply to physical features is critical to understanding how they apply to clothing, accessories, makeup and hair.

Translated into body types, yin and yang manifest as:

Yin [Feminine Energy]: Curved lines, round edges, flowing silhouettes, hourglass figures, fitted waists, rounded shapes, swirls, curves, circles

sharp edges, slim, circular silhouettes, elongated outlines, geometric shapes, rectangles, triangles

While the main characteristic of yin is softness and roundness, this can be expressed through both youthfulness and sexuality. Hence we can discern two different types of yin:

Petite yin is characterised by small hands and feet, small noses and delicate bone structure etc. Features that are **lush yin** are large eyes, full lips, and hourglass silhouettes etc.

Yang, on the other hand, manifests as angularity and sharpness. While yin has plenty of organic shapes and curved lines, yang is all about angles and geometric shapes. Again, there are different types of yang:

Sharp yang is seen in vertical lines, narrowness, pointed edges, long and lean bodies, and prominent jawlines. **Soft yang** refers to horizontal lines, broadness, blunt edges, square silhouettes, a tendency towards muscularity and wider noses. In the picture above, you can see how the principle of yin and yang takes shape in the archetypes. And this is key to determining the Kibbe archetypes. We need to understand **the lines that are native to yin and yang.**



Yin is defined by roundness and curves. And this is perfectly demonstrated by Marilyn Monroe on the left. Her body type is rounded and curvy, and there are no sharp edges or angles. She has an hourglass figure, a full, round bustline and rounded hips. Even her shoulders are rounded. Her body is also very soft and fleshy. If we look at her face, we can see more roundness. She has round eyes, a rounded nose and full, round lips. Her jawline and cheekbones appear soft and round. They are covered by lots of flesh, giving her a soft appearance. Marilyn is an example of lush yin.

Let's now compare her to Keira Knightley on the right. Remember, yang is defined by angles and sharpness. Keira's figure is long and straight with no waist emphasis. Her body flesh is very taut with no signs of fleshiness. Similarly, her face is constructed of angles. Her eyes are straight, her cheekbones are prominent, her nose is sharp,



very pronounced and angular. Her facial features are also very taut, making the bones underneath very visible. Keira is an example of Sharp Yang.

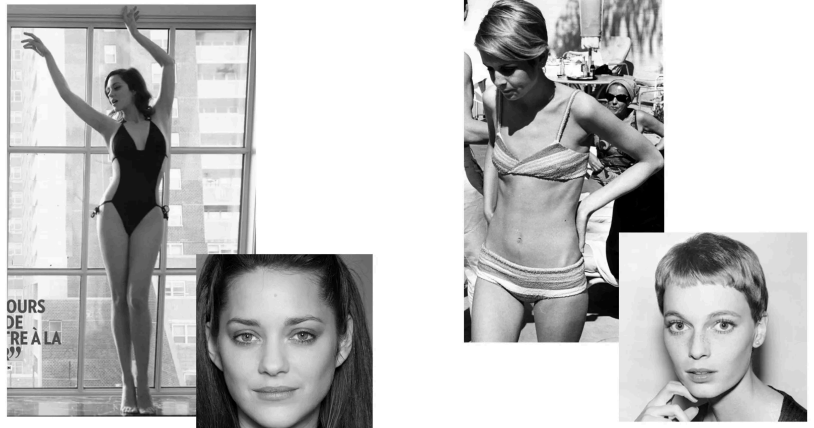
Note that the principles of yin and yang are not related to body weight. Marilyn Monroe is not overweight in this picture. Yin body flesh is always soft and fleshy, even if underweight.

Contrast & Blend

The terms contrast and blend refer to the way Yin and Yang are mixed within a body.

If a body consists of a combination of physical features that are **distinctly yin or distinctly yang, this would result in a contrasting body type.** For example, a person with a large forehead (yang), big and round eyes (yin), a small and delicate nose (yin), thin lips (yang), and a small chin (yin) would be considered contrasted.

Blended features, in contrast, are those that are **neither distinctly yin or yang;** they are a mix of both. For example, instead of either large and round (yin) or small and straight (yang) eyes, a person may have moderate, almond-shaped eyes. Or a person may have neither a very small (yin) nor a very straight waist (yang), but a softly defined waist. Again, this feature would fall someone in the middle of the yin/yang scale and would be a blend of the two energies.



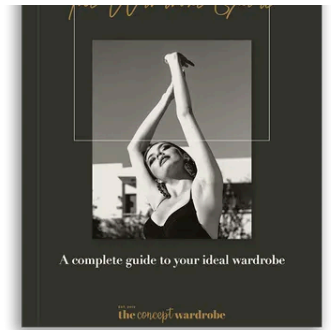
You can see in the picture above that Marion Cotillard has blended features. She doesn't have a full hourglass figure, but neither does she have a very straight figure like Keira Knightley above. She is somewhere in the middle, a blend between Yin and Yang. You can see the same principle in her face. Her eyes are neither very large and round, nor very small and straight. Instead, they are moderate in size and evenly spaced. The same with her lips: neither very full and round nor very thin and straight.

Mia Farrow on the right side demonstrates contrasting features. Her body is very Yang dominant - it looks much like Keira's body. Her face also shows signs of sharpness around her cheek and jaw area. However, her eyes are very large and round and therefore Yin features. This is a contrasting body type.



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III. The 5 Type Families

Although there are 13 body types in total, there are **five type families**. These are pure types. The other 8 body types are mixtures of these pure types, and that's where things can get confusing. So before we can understand the mixed types, let's first discuss the pure types or type families.

Below you will find an overview of the yin/yang spectrum. On the left side are the type families that are more yang influenced (Dramatic and Natural). On the right side are the yin influenced type families (Gamine and Romantic). And in the middle is the balanced yin/yang family (Classic).

YANG			YIN	
Dramatic	Natural	Classic	Gamine	Romantic
<i>Sharp Yang</i>	<i>Soft Yang</i>	<i>Balanced</i>	<i>Petite Yin</i>	<i>Lush Yin</i>



body & bone structure, body, feet and facial

features (facial bones + facial flesh). All three sections of your body can have a different yin/yang balance. But what makes the pure types pure is that all three areas of their bodies have the same yin/yang balance.

Dramatic

The Dramatic family sits on the very left of the yin/yang spectrum and is defined by **sharp yang**. This type family has **no yin influence**. That means a Dramatic will **appear very elongated with sharp edges**. A Dramatic body type has the following physical characteristics:

Bone Structure:

- They appear very tall, narrow, and elongated
- Their shoulders are narrow with sharp edges
- They have long arms and legs
- Their hands and feet are large and narrow

Body Flesh:

- They have a flat bust line, straight waistline, and straight hips
- The flesh on their bodies is very taut

- They have prominent, sharp, and angular facial features (nose, cheekbones, jawline)
- They have small, close-spaced eyes, straight, thin lips, and taut cheek flesh

All **A answers** on the Kibbe Body Type Test are Dramatic features.

Natural

The Natural family is also **yang dominant but to a slightly lesser degree (soft yang)**. There is a small amount of yin in the blended mix. That means that while they are still angular, their edges are less sharp and blunter. A Natural body type has the following physical characteristics:

Bone Structure:

- They appear tall but broad
- Their shoulders are wide with blunt edges
- They have long arms and legs
- Their hands and feet are large and wide

Body Flesh:

- They have a wide, flat-ish bust line, straight and wide waistline, and straight hips

Facial Features:

- They have wide, angular facial features (nose, cheekbones, jawline) with blunt edges
- They have wide-spaced eyes, straight, broad lips, and muscular cheek flesh

All **B answers** on the Kibbe Body Type test are Natural features.

Classic

The Classic family is characterised by a **balanced *blend* of yin and yang**. They will appear very **symmetrical with moderate features**. A Classic body type has the following physical characteristics:

Bone Structure:

- They look their actual, moderate height
- Their shoulders are neither fully straight nor sloped
- They have moderate arms and legs
- Their hands and feet are moderately proportioned

Body Flesh:

- The flesh on their bodies is neither very taut nor very curvy but evenly proportioned

Facial Features:

- They have very symmetrical and proportionate facial features (nose, cheekbones, jawline)
- They have moderate eyes, lips, and cheek flesh

All **C answers** on the Kibbe Body Type test are Classic features.

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Gamine

The Gamine family is characterised by a **combination of yin and yang**. This is different from Classics as a Gamine's features will not be blended but will be either (petite) yin or (sharp) yang. A Gamine body type has the following physical characteristics:

Bone Structure:

- They look petite, but their bones are angular and straight
- Their shoulders are sloped and tapered
- They have long arms and legs

Body Flesh:

- They have a straight bust line, waistline, and hips
- The flesh on their bodies is quite lean

Facial Features:

- They have angular facial features (nose, cheekbones, jawline)
- They have large eyes, moderate to thin lips, and taut cheek flesh

Some **D answers** on the Kibbe Body Type test are Gamine features.

Romantic

The Romantic family sits on the far right end of the Yin/Yang spectrum and is characterised by **lush yin, with no yang influence**. They will appear very soft with round edges. A Romantic body type has the following physical characteristics:

Bone Structure:

- They appear delicate and shorter than they are
- Their shoulders are sloped with round edges

- Their hands and feet are small

Body Flesh:

- They have a full bust line, a full hourglass figure, and curvy, rounded hips
- The flesh on their bodies is very soft, voluptuous, and fleshy (even when at ideal weight)

Facial Features:

- They have small, delicate facial features (nose, cheekbones, jawline) with round edges
- They have large, rounded eyes, full lips, and round cheekbones

All **E answers** on the Kibbe Body Type test are Romantic features.

The remaining 8 body types are a combination of the pure types. Most people are one of the mixed types. Pure types are quite rare.

Below you will find each type family together with their subtypes. Each family - with the exceptions of Dramatic and Romantic - has **two subtypes, one leaning more towards yang than the pure type and one leaning more towards yin than the pure type**. Dramatic and Romantic



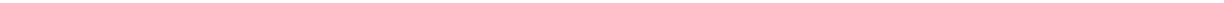
are already at the very end of the yin/yang spectrum, so there is nowhere else to go from there.

YANG			YIN	
Dramatic	Natural	Classic	Gamine	Romantic
<i>Sharp Yang</i>	<i>Soft Yang</i>	<i>Balanced</i>	<i>Petite Yin</i>	<i>Lush Yin</i>
Soft Dramatic	Flamboyant Natural	Dramatic Classic	Flamboyant Gamine	Theatrical Romantic
	Soft Natural	Soft Classic	Soft Gamine	

The following table shows the yin/yang distribution for each type and the type of yin/yang. For example, a Soft Dramatic has a sharp yang bone structure (as outlined under Dramatic above), but lush yin body flesh and facial flesh (as outlined under Romantic above).

	Bone Structure (incl. Facial Bones)	Body Flesh	Facial Flesh
Dramatic	Sharp Yang	Sharp Yang	Sharp Yang
Soft Dramatic	Sharp Yang	Lush Yin	Lush Yin
Flamboyant Natural	Sharp Yang	Soft Yang	Soft Yang
Natural	Soft Yang	Soft Yang	Soft Yang
Soft Natural	Soft Yang	Petite Yin/Lush Yin	Petite Yin/Lush Yin
Dramatic Classic	Sharp Yang	Balanced	Balanced
Classic	Balanced	Balanced	Balanced
Soft Classic	Balanced	Petite Yin/Lush Yin	Petite Yin/Lush Yin
Flamboyant Gamine	Sharp Yang	Petite Yin/Lush Yin	Petite Yin/Lush Yin
Gamine	Sharp Yang	Sharp Yang	Lush Yin
Soft Gamine	Sharp Yang	Petite Yin/Lush Yin	Petite Yin/Lush Yin
Theatrical Romantic	Lush Yin with Sharp Yang	Petite Yin/Lush Yin	Petite Yin/Lush Yin
Romantic	Lush Yin	Lush Yin	Lush Yin

Next, we will walk through the **Kibbe Body Type test** to determine your Kibbe body type (archetype).





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K

Katie Todd

3 years ago

I literally don't fit into any of these lol, my body type must be just too weird

1 0 Reply

L

Laurel Shelhamer

4 years ago

I was immediately impressed with the Gamine body type because it reminded me of my appearance during my late teens through early adulthood. But I had learned about the Kibbe body types from a YouTube channel . The creator is a delightful creature who is limited only by English being her second language.. (That and a preoccupation with disguise and Photo Shop.). Thankfully, I made a conscious decision to read carefully and follow the instructions, without bias.

I was surprised to learn that I fit squarely into Pure Classic. (Not without dispute!) But this was now and that was then!? I considered that I was on a diet and that my body and shape will change slightly. It was then I that i noticed where Gamine was located on the scale of body types. Our instincts are generally close, if not spot on. So I felt safe with the Kimberly test results.

Thank you so very much for taking the time to translate Kibbe! And I am really happy that you provided links to the original document! My experience prevents me (and most thinking persons), from trusting anything short of,, "Don't Shoot the Panda," lol! And nothing less!

1 0 Reply



Jennifer Ann Serr

a year ago

I'm a little confused - I tested Bone Structure D (Gamine), Body Flesh E (Romantic) and Facial Features C (Classic)....Does that make me a soft Gamine? very cuious

0 0 Reply

S

Sana Ijaz

3 years ago

Hello. I believe I am a combination of dramatic, gamine and romantic. Not exactly sure but it's in order of bone structure, body flesh and facial features.

0 0 Reply



I'm probably going to do the test wrong because I've always assumed Angelina is under 5'10 and Katy has always looked taller to me.

0 0 Reply

L

Liberrate Mysz



5 years ago

Hi Nicole,

I analysed my appearance and took Kibbe test. I have results sharp yang both in bone structure and body flesh like a pure dramatic, but my facial features are different: rather big and rounded eyes, rather full lips, more sharpen nose rather than rounded, taut cheeks, oblong face with round jawline. So by the table at the end of this article I have an ideal Gamine type.

But in Gamine description there are differences to me. I have very long vertical line (not petite), my shoulders aren't sloped by any means, are narrow and sharp. I have long arms and legs, yes, and long and narrow feet and hands. My bone structure is pure from dramatic type, but everything else is from Gamine type. Am I a blend of dramatic with Gamine? I think these types are mutually exclusive so I don't know what to get from... Can you help me? I would be so glad!

All the best

Meggi

0 0 Reply

T

the concept wardrobe Mod

→ Liberrate Mysz



5 years ago

Hi Meggi, to be completely frank, I'm not the biggest Kibbe fan because it limits you to only one type. I much prefer style essences, which allow you to have a blend of multiple types. I encourage you to look into these (test coming soon!).

2 0 Reply



tiffanyima

→ the concept wardrobe



5 years ago

I've been reading more about the types, and it seems to work well if you fit clearly into the category. Harder if you're a blend. That said I'm pretty sure I'm theatrical romantic!

1 0 Reply

K

Kathryn Tobacco

→ Liberrate Mysz



3 years ago

Sorry to necro-post but my best friend is extremely tall and looks tall for her height- 5'10. She has a small head and a Gamine pixie face, as in she looks like Tinkerbell. She is very pretty too- like drop dead gorgeous. She is a mix of ying and yang if I ever saw it. Oh her feet and hands are small for her height too. She has broad shoulders and she looks great in halter style dresses and tops or anything that cuts away and shows off her shoulders which are very pretty and not masculine despite the fact they are broad. She couldn't figure out her type and I don't think she fits well into the system. Also I never understand the "narrow shoulder" question. Are "narrow" shoulders narrow from side to side or

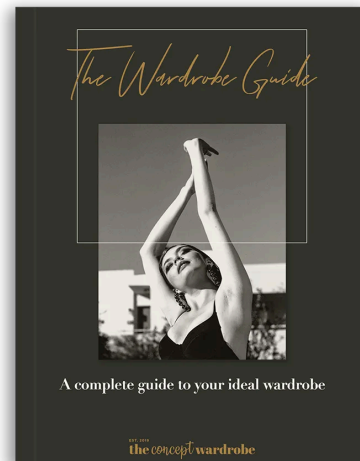


THE WARDROBE GUIDE

How do you build *a flattering and functional wardrobe?*

Buying a bunch of clothes because they look nice in the shop is not a good strategy for building a wardrobe. It implies that the look of your clothes is more important than your look. But clothes should have no other purpose than to bring out your natural beauty and to highlight it.

The wardrobe guide will help you discover those garments that truly suit you.



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